

18TH-CENTURY SHIP OF THE LINE

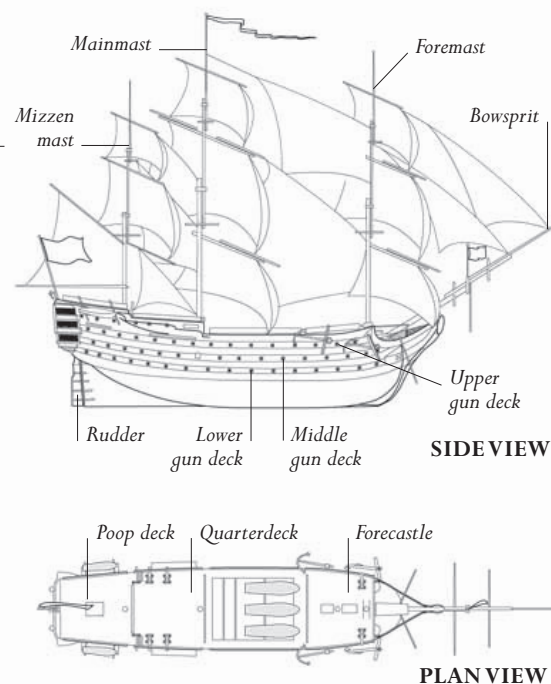
HMS VICTORY

A first-rate ship of the line, the *Victory* won fame as Admiral Horatio Nelson's flagship when the British Royal Navy triumphed over the Spanish and French fleets at the Battle of Trafalgar, in 1805.

More than 6,000 trees – mostly oak – were felled for *Victory*'s construction. Launched in 1765, it was not commissioned until war with France broke out in 1778, and the ship saw its first action at the Battle of Ushant. It later became the Royal Navy's flagship in the Mediterranean and led the action that destroyed the Spanish fleet at the Battle of Cape St Vincent, in 1797. By then the *Victory* was showing its age, so at the end of 1797 it was retired to serve as a hospital ship. This decision was soon reconsidered,

and, after being repaired, the *Victory* was recommissioned as Nelson's flagship, in 1803. Two years later it played a key role in the Battle of Trafalgar, with 57 men killed, including her admiral, and 102 injured. The ship remained in active service until 1812.

The *Victory* carried 820 men, including 146 marines. Its 104 smoothbore, muzzle-loading cannon gave it immense firepower: in comparison, the entire French army at the Battle of Austerlitz, in the same year as Trafalgar, fielded 139 cannon.



▲ HMS VICTORY

The ship was up to 16m (52ft) wide, and the gun-deck length was 57m (187ft). The 37 sails had a combined area of 5,468 sq m (6,510 sq yards).

TOWARDS THE STERN



◀ STERN

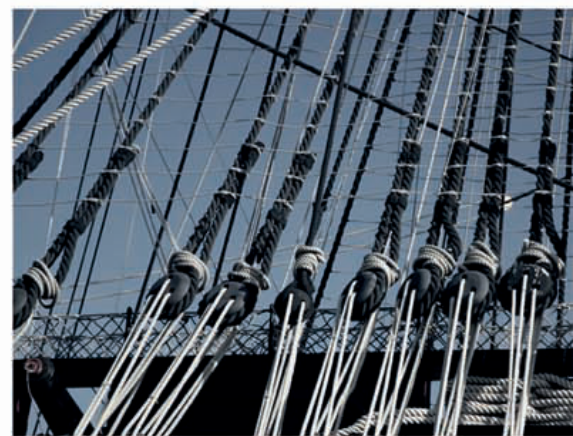
Housed in the rear of the ship were the cabins of the admiral, captain, and other officers. There was less decoration on the *Victory*'s stern than on earlier ships of her kind.

MASTS AND RIGGING



▲ MAINMAST

The three masts are supported by ropes called standing rigging. With men climbing along the yard arms to set or furl the sails, fatal falls were common.



▲ ROPE LADDER

"Shrouds" are standing rigging ropes fitted to the ship's sides; "ratlines" run across them, forming ladders up the masts.



▲ WHEEL AND BINNACLE

The double wheel, located aft on the quarterdeck and under the poop, was operated by four men in calm weather and up to eight in a storm. The binnacle, in front of the wheel, holds a lantern and two compasses.



▲ GUN PORTS

The ports were opened and closed using ropes located on the gun decks. The muzzles of the guns are blocked by tompions (plugs that are designed to keep out dust and moisture).